

VertiGO!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 680 July 2005 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

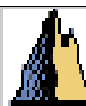
Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards.



1 August 2005 – DEREK CHINN

Derek will be talking about Everest and other climbs. He is a civil engineer and designed French Ridge, Mueller, Albert and Plateau Huts. Derek describes himself as “a spectacularly unaccomplished rockclimber and incompetent mountaineer” but adds that he has been good at selecting “competent and longsuffering partners!” Derek has done some amazing climbs all over the world. Several NZAC members have requested that we ask him to come and speak to us so this is your chance to hear a talk not to be missed!





Section trips news

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.



Autumn Rock 2005

C is for....

When you find someone jamming their feet into shoes three sizes too small, you can be sure adventure is about to happen... and when you are sure adventure is about to happen, you naturally want to be a part of it..... and if you're not doing anything, you should always do something, but it is best if you know what you are attempting to do before you attempt to do it....

...and so began Autumn Rock 2005....

It is essential to master the basics first, and as such, the preliminary technique classes proved invaluable. It soon became clear that distinguishing between left and right was a prerequisite for progressing any further, along with the vital skill of mumbling incoherently under your breath so no one knows what you're really thinking or how scared you really are. Useful training tips were also passed on, such as if your fingers are not bleeding at every joint you are clearly doing something wrong. Definitely worth remembering.

So once equipped with the necessary expertise, students were introduced to the first of two of the North Island's premier rock climbing venues – Whanganui Bay. The Bay trip took place over the last weekend in April - days of endless sunshine (apart from the rain on Sunday), real rock, seconding big climbs, 50m rappels, and the emergence of the Custard Monster. What would you do for \$5? Drink a spare litre of cold custard, perhaps.

Following this, a long period of inclement weather and consequent trip postponements allowed technique to be honed and hubris to brew. Students enjoyed a bouldering trip to Baring Head (only if you are a serious climber will you wade through an icy cold stream up to your waist and think nothing of it...), a bonus anchor session at the wall, an introduction to lead climbing, and an impromptu lesson in the laws of physics: If you try and clip an entire arm's length (and the rest!) above your head, you WILL fall from the last bolt, you WILL fall the entire length of the climb, it WILL result in a near body slam and potential decapitation of your belayer, and you WILL look like an idiot.

But finally, after weeks of frustrated waiting, we were rewarded with a bonus day on our Queen's Birthday long weekend trip to Wharepapa, where we enjoyed more climbing under New Zealand's azure blue skies (apart from the rain on Saturday and the closure of routes 1 and 4 on the way up due to snow) and our first introduction to outdoor lead sport climbing. The rock at Wharepapa quietly witnessed some really fine climbing and commitment by all of the students, a little blood, the odd expletive, and more vital lessons learned. Coming in at number 1 – a true contender for the all time top climbing tip: Don't clip in with your chalk bag - it's just not the same as a quickdraw. A worthy second, and also an ancient Chinese proverb: "He who drop belay device from top of climb get useful practice in down-climbing". And a third useful lesson in the importance of warming up on some nice easy 25's.

Overall, the course was outstanding. We began as novices and due to the skill, patience and enthusiasm of the instructors, by the last weekend most of us were confident to lead sport climbs in the 16 to 18 range, set up an anchor and abseil back down. Everyone enjoyed getting to know the culture that is climbing and

some of the people that are a part of it. A great time was had by all, and the instructors really were true bright and shining stars! Scott, Mike, Michele, Blair, Clark, Simon, Derek, Annette – awesome.

Annabel Smith



AIC Instructors weekend

Instructors headed North on Friday July 8 to refresh skills and complete planning for the 2005 AIC Course. This year there are 18 students participating in the course and Course Coordinator, Caroline Duggan has had her hands full (Caro, Leave those boys alone!) arranging accommodation, transport, food and all the other things that it takes to put together a successful course for 18 students. One of the biggest issues facing the Club these days is ensuring that all the safety issues are addressed. For those who did their training even only a few years ago there have been some changes in techniques, particularly in the setting of soft snow anchors. The biggest change is the advent of the mid-clipped snow stake. (details of this can be found in the new MSC Alpine Skills Manual). Several tests were conducted with the anchor and the more traditional tee slots and pigs and it was generally found to work very well, comparable to a tee slot in strength. The course starts on Friday 15 July and everyone is feeling pretty keen about getting into it.

Garth London

As we go to print the first weekend of AIC has taken place and it was fab! More details to come (Ed.)



Pete's Post from Antarctica

last night i had a great idea for my Vertigo piece this month. I decided to start writing it in the morning. Today I am able to remember that I needed to write this article, and that I came up with a theme last night. But I can't remember what the actual idea was. So I'll tell you about Polar T3 syndrome, which most winter-over personnel seem to suffer from. One of the symptoms is forgetfulness.

We've all been medically and psychologically cleared as fit for wintering-over in Antarctica. We were recruited partly because we're supposed to possess personality traits that will allow us to cope with the isolation, cold, darkness, and living in a close community of workmates. And we've all got a sense of humour that makes us laugh at the silly things we sometimes find ourselves doing.

All of us at Scott Base have had experiences like collecting the tools to do a job, walking to the other end of the base, and then trying to remember what the actual job was. Or walking to the computer to send an email, and then forgetting who we wanted to write to.

My memory is normally much better than this when I'm living in NZ, and my workmates are the same. So why are we affected like this? It actually doesn't come as a surprise to us - we were well briefed on this by a psychologist, Dr Gary Steel, during our pre-deployment training in Christchurch. Research has shown that people who work in Antarctica experience a decline of thyroid hormone products, dulled thinking, lethargy, and mood disturbances.

Through the production of thyroid hormones, the thyroid gland is involved in regulating metabolism - how the body uses energy and at what speed. Researchers believe that living in Antarctica causes the muscles to hoard thyroid hormone in order to warm the body, at the expense of the brain. Whenever the

concentration of thyroid hormone in the blood dips too low (hypothyroidism), metabolism slows and fatigue, poor memory, weight gain and depression set in. This condition is called "polar T3 syndrome" (T3 is one of the thyroid hormones) when it is caused by living in the Antarctic.

More than half the people who stay through the Antarctic winter go through actual physical changes. Their metabolism generally increases by about 40 percent. As their hormone levels change, people become forgetful, depressed and tired. Typically people feel some change soon after they arrive on the Ice in October or November, as their bodies adapt. Their mood and energy levels improve midway through the summer season and peak near the end of the summer, and then drop again in midwinter. As the winter goes on these mood changes can be more of a drain on your energy. People have been known to stare into space for minutes at a time in what is called the "Antarctic stare." By the end of winter they may be, in Antarctic lingo, "toast".

That's one of the reasons the NZ Antarctic program doesn't allow us to winter-over for two successive years.

We manage this condition by being organised with our work, by writing lists, and by keeping to regular schedules. We need to be tolerant of other people's forgetfulness, and not take offence when someone reminds us of a job we had promised to do for them.

Actually, it's not as bad as it sounds. I notice it most when Scott Base hosts a quiz-night for our American neighbours. Often I'm aware that I should know the answer to a question, but can't quite recall it. Doing a crossword is another time when it is noticeable. It's not too different from the slightly impaired reasoning and memory processes I've experienced at high altitude (above 5000 metres).

Some of our staff have suffered from sleeping problems. This is common when you don't have any sunrises and sunsets to regulate your day. I'm lucky enough to have had no problems like this, but other staff went for days without sleep during the summer. One person had to be stood down from her regular duties in the interests of safety, and was also prescribed sleeping pills. It was still another few days before she was able to get to sleep. In winter, people often have difficulty in waking up, or experience drowsiness during the day.

Lack of vitamin D or low exposure to sunlight is apparently related to hormone production and therefore to the changes in our metabolism. According to an article I've just read, Vitamin D is actually NOT a vitamin because the body can and does synthesize all that it needs. Vitamin D is really a hormone synthesized by the action of sunlight on plant sterols found in our skin. Our body levels of Vitamin D are only slightly affected by dietary sources such as milk fortified with Vitamin D and Vitamin pills. Because Vitamin D is fat-soluble, this hormone can be stored in our body fat for long periods of time. Therefore, intermittent exposure to sunlight is adequate. Our minimum requirement for sunlight is small and most people in their daily activities easily meet it, as long as they live in places where the sun is visible.

The American base, McMurdo Station, has a room with special full-spectrum lighting where you can sit and relax. They also have a hydroponics room where fresh vegetables and herbs are grown. Visitors are welcome, due to the therapeutic affects of the artificial sunlight. Scott Base used to have a hydroponics room, but it became infected with the small springtail insect (which is the largest land animal in Antarctica - seals are considered marine animals). It had to be shut down for decontamination. Plans are underway for the hydroponics room to be recommissioned again, but some of our engineering people appear reluctant due to the cost of the fuel required to generate electricity for the lights and pumps.

Anyway, that's enough for this month - I'd better go and do something else. The only problem is that I've forgotten what else I was supposed to be doing

!!

Pete De Joux from Antarctica



39 Mercer Street, PO Box 1560, Wellington, New Zealand
Ph/Fax (04) 4735353 email mainly.tramping@paradise.net.nz



Instruction Course

The NZAC National Instruction Committee is looking at possible options for instruction courses. One idea is around a Refresher Course, to update those people who have climbed before (but perhaps have had a break, or never or not recently done any instruction) and are looking to up skill on current techniques/best practice. If you think this might be a course you would be interested in doing please let the convener, Caroline Duggan, know on cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or 04 475 5542 to gauge whether there would be enough interest to run such a course.



Quiz Numbers 19 and 20

The Answer to Quiz Number 19

Nigel Roberts' 19th quiz was what is the modern name of the mountain to which Prometheus was chained, and why is the mountain particularly well-known?

The answer is Mt Elbrus (which is in southern Russia); and -- as it is the highest mountain in Europe -- it's well-known as one of the seven summits.

Natasha Gale's entry was drawn from the correct answers that were submitted, and she thus received a bottle of 'Seven Terraces' white wine.

Quiz Number 20

Nigel Roberts turned down an invitation to dinner with President Marie-Nöelle Thémereau because of his prior commitment to chair the July Wellington section-night meeting. His 20th quiz question is thus:

What is the highest mountain in the independent state of which President Marie-Nöelle Thémereau is a citizen?

Email your answers to nr@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz by no later than noon on Sunday, 31 July 2005 with 'Quiz Number 20' in the subject line (otherwise your email is likely to be destroyed as spam!). The winner will receive a bottle of wine from said independent state.



For Sale/Wanted to buy

for Lend: Personal Locator Beacon for lend

I have an emergency locator beacon. When I am not using it, which is quite a few weekends, it is essentially a useless lump of plastic. If people want to borrow it for their weekend trips, then they can borrow it off me. It is hardly going to depreciate with use. Club members might as well get as much use out of it as possible. I just hope that while people carry it, they don't have to "use" it. Know what I mean?

Anyway, the offer is there. People can contact me on this e-mail address if they want to borrow it.

Sam

Samuel.Newton@nzpost.co.nz

For sale: Adjustable 12 point crampons with key in Charlet Moset crampon bag.

Good condition.

\$140.

Contact Chris on 021 307 353.

For sale: Salomon SM Lite Boots, Size 8

\$200

Contact garth.london@forman.co.nz 027 4470 399

For sale: (Because they are too small) Used on only one major trip

Koflach Vertical plastic boots UK 9 (the yellow ones)

\$100.00

Macpac Microlight Tent excellent condition

\$300

Contact Craig Robinson

baldrick001@paradise.net.nz 021894002

Wanted to buy: Helmet, general mountaineering iceaxe, adjustable strap-on crampons.

Contact Scott Julian on 021 308 377

Wanted to borrow: Ski Touring Equipment

Looking for anyone who have ski touring equipment they would not mind lending to club members for the purposes of the ski touring weekend planned for 27-28 August. In particular skis, touring bindings and skins. If you think you might be able to help, please contact trip co-ordinator Mike Judd - mike.judd@fire.org.nz



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Training for Mountaineering

"I suggest going out to the nearest pub and getting completely, and utterly, wasted. Make sure you smoke at least 1 pack of unfiltered Camel's. Get the full ashtray, pour a drink in it and then pour the mixture into a water bottle.

When you get home (ideally around 3:30am) stick the vile mixture into your freezer. Put on your best goretex and thermal layer. Climb in. At 5:30am, get out, drink (chew?) the mixture and go run the biggest flight of stairs you can find. Run until your heart threatens to explode.

Your dehydration caused by the alcohol should adequately simulate what you may experience at higher altitudes. Your lung capacity should be sufficiently impaired by the smokes to simulate a oxygen poor environment. The freezer episode should adequately replicate a bivy. Drinking the booze/butt mixture should simulate your lack of appetite.....

Oh — once your finished your workout, go to work (to replicate the long walk out)."

Greg Hamilton suggesting an altitude training methodology.



Job hunting tips for mountaineers

"Found the following in a local post by someone describing what they look for in a resume when hiring a person for a computer programming job: Flowery action words can't hide a lack of accomplishment in life. I like it when someone lists things like 'mountain climbing' in their resume, because it means he's geeky enough to feel it's necessary to prove that he's not a geek, yet not so geeky that he's anal retentive." Paul Hess.



...More Quotes

"The distinguishing mark of true adventures, is that it is often no fun at all while they are actually happening." - Kim Stanley Robinson



Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, come and chat to Merewyn Ellis (trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

See you in the hills!

WE NEED MORE TRIPS! COME ON GUYS

Trips for the Calendar for the rest of 2005...

Check out the proposed and planned new list for 2005. We need trip organisers to put their hands up for what are bound to be outstanding adventures. There's something for everyone in here with a mix of snow, rock and even a spot of ski touring.

Mt Arapiles (Australia)

Type: Rock climbing

All levels

In association with the new Australian section, who will be helping to co-ordinate transport from Melbourne, central cooking tent etc. A great chance to visit an amazing climbing area and meet our Aussie club members.

Organiser: Judy Reid jr@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

Mid November 05, date to be confirmed.

Whakapapa

Type: Ski Touring

Beginner

A 'have a go' weekend for people who have always wanted to try ski touring. So, beg, steal, borrow some gear and come along. Experienced tourers also very welcome.

Organiser: Mike Judd mike.judd@fire.org.nz

27-28 August 05

Ruapehu

Type: AIC Follow-up trip

Beginner/Intermediate

Consolidate your new skills. Based at the NZAC Ruapehu hut at Delta Corner.

Organiser: Caroline Duggan cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

1-2 October 05



HANGDOG INDOOR CLIMBING CAVERN

Come down and see us for all your climbing and bouldering needs. We have heaps of good routes from grade 14 through to 30 and the only bouldering room in Wellington!

It only costs NZAC members \$8.00 to climb with ID, and you get 20% off all climbing gear!

HangDog and Top Adventures
453 Hutt Rd, Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181



...and More Qoutes...

"I was once bouldering in solitude in the Needles, when a young female walked up and introduced herself and asked who I was. I told her and continued bouldering. She turned and walked away after a few minutes, saying over her shoulder: 'you can't be John Gill. He climbs much better than that'." —John Gill

"—You guys going up?

—Yes, yes, we go up

—You may be going a lot higher than you think !" —Don Whillans, to a Japanese party, while retreating off the north face of Eiger in a storm.



Glossary

"**Artificial climbing:** knack of appearing to climb by talking about it. This technique is best employed far from actual climbing areas, which tend to be hazardous. Small taverns and pizza parlors with an impressionable clientele are excellent sites for artificial climbing."

"**Blood /n./** substance commonly used to mark a climbing route."

"**Line of weakness:** long involved explanation for not attempting a route."

"**Mountaineering /n./** slow walking uphill while not feeling very well."

"**Offwidth crack /n./** remark made in a smartass manner."

"**Volcano /n./** A mountain with hiccups."

"**Wilderness /n./** archaic word used to refer to the space that once existed between urban areas and which is now used as a proving ground for 4-wheel drive vehicles."

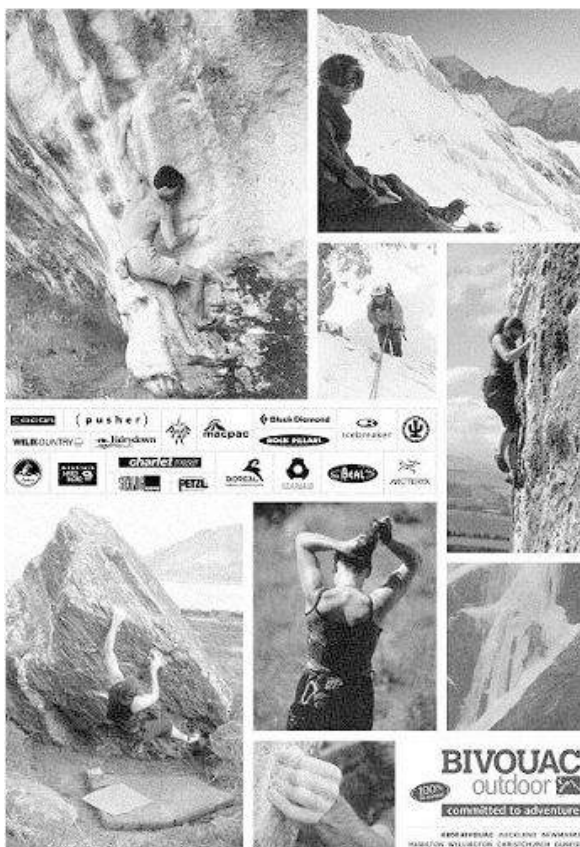


Bored at work?

Check out:

www.mountainz.co.nz

www.mojozone.co.nz



MOVED HOUSE?

Please notify the Club's National Administrator of your change of address as the labels for all newsletters and club publications are generated at the HQ office.

You can contact:

Margaret McMahon
National Administrator
email office@alpineclub.org.nz

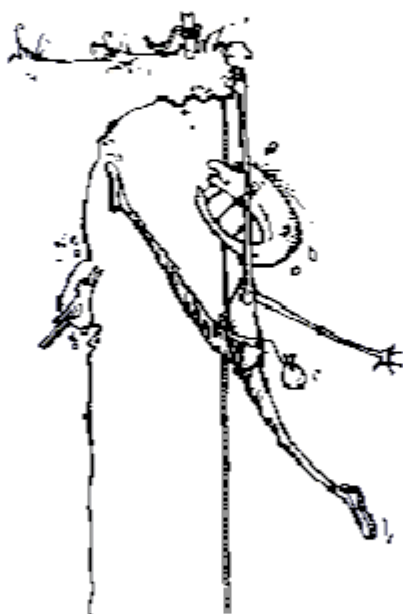
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Wellington Section Directory: 2005 contact list

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Vice Chairperson	Garth London	GL	(04) 479 2984
Secretary	Tom Bowen	SECRETARY <i>or</i> TB	
Treasurer	Rachel Depree	TREASURER <i>or</i> RD	
National Representative	Caroline Duggan	CD	(04) 475 5542
	Nigel Roberts	NR	(04) 475 7543
Instruction: AIC	Caroline Duggan	AIC <i>or</i> CD	(04) 475 5542
Instruction: RIC	Scott Taylor	SPRINGROCK	N/A
Trips	Merewyn Ellis	ME	N/A
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
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* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



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